Pollution through the ages

Human-made pollution has a long history. The presence of soot on the walls of caves, dating back thousands of years, indicates that early humans generated air pollution from their fires. Analysis of 2,500-year-old ice cores in Greenland has shown evidence of air pollution from copper smelting thousands of miles away, in the center of the Roman Empire. However, such impacts were on a small scale. With the start of the Industrial Revolution in Europe, air and water pollution became serious. Factory chimneys pumped smoke out into the air; toxic chemicals poured into rivers. Cities expanded quickly and had no sanitation. The Thames River, in London, was both the source of water for domestic use and the outlet for untreated human sewage. Disease spread, river fish were wiped out, and the smell was sometimes unbearable. Other urban centers fared little better: similarly unsanitary conditions were recorded in Berlin in 1870, for example.

In the United States, the first two cities to enact laws to ensure clean air were Chicago and Cincinnati, in 1881. By that time, the manure from 3 million horses pulling wagons in North American cities was seeping into water supplies and producing plagues of disease-causing flies. As horses were gradually replaced by the internal combustion engine, smog from cars and trucks became a major issue. London's Great Smog of 1952, described as a "pea-souper" for the color of the filthy air, killed more than 4,000 people.

"Air pollution control systems still lag behind economic development."

Bob O'Keefe